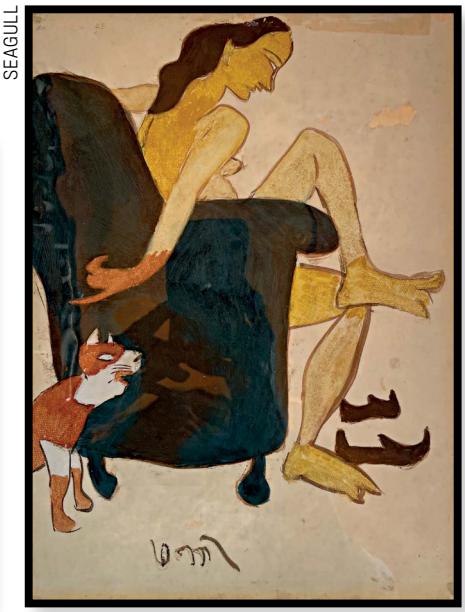

EMAMI ART


SEAGULL

Brushstrokes & More
(Clockwise from left) *Paintings 'Cat and Humans' and Seagull; and a toy made of bamboo, wood and leather*

ART

Centennial Man

A seminal exhibition of K.G. Subramanyan's works in his birth centenary year at Emami Art, Kolkata takes an imaginative and immersive curatorial approach



K.G. Subramanyan was one of the most important artists of the post-independence Indian Modernists. Differently from the Progressives of Bombay and others, KG (as he was widely known) was also a bridge between Santiniketan Modernism and the energetic *manthan* of work that developed in India from the 1950s onwards. In a career spanning nearly 70 years, KG produced brilliant, amazingly varied work in various mediums.

Superb draughtsman, wicked colourist, constantly funny and witty, with a deep yet deeply un-pompous connection to the subcontinent's long historical visual vernacular, KG's work has been recognised and viewed in several exhibitions during and after his lifetime. The challenge for any curator is to bring the work afresh to viewers. In this, Nancy Adajania's show—*One Hundred Years and Counting: Re-Scripting KG Subramanyan*—at Emami Art, Kolkata (on till June 21) succeeds beautifully.

Rather than give us a 'usual suspect' chronological-cum-hagiographical mounting, Adajania has chosen a more complex route, but with a light touch that reflects the light touch for which KG himself was known. As we enter the show, we are drawn into a KG-world rather than a mere parade of works. On the floors and walls are enlarged graphic motifs from the artist's children's books, the black shapes immediately recognisable as classic KG and yet made unfamiliar by the scale and unexpected placement. The work is presented in thematic clusters rather than in any obvious chronology of 'development'. You see the images, visual tropes and stories to which the painter returned again and again across seven decades of work. There are collective projects including the beautiful animal toys he designed in partnership with traditional craftspeople. Throughout the exhibition there are windows and pressure valves that release you into the contexts that help situate what you are looking at. On one screen is a repeated loop from Ritwik Ghatak's film *Subarnarekha*, where little Sita, wandering at an abandoned airfield, is suddenly accosted by a *bohurupiya* (impersonator).


EMAMI ART

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KG loved the idea of the fluid character shifting of the *bohurupiya* and Adajania argues that in his work he was a constant shape-shifter himself, moving from paint to wood to terracotta and ceramics and back to painted flat works; in terms of subject too, KG was capable of moving from depictions of domestic intimacy and multifarious eroticisms to political satire. As the title of the show indicates, this may be a 100th anniversary show but K.G. Subramanyan's work is as fresh, challenging and invigorating as ever. ■

–Ruchir Joshi